



You might be **bottle-feeding** your baby if you are **combination feeding**, moving on to formula **after breast-feeding**, or maybe breast-feeding just hasn't worked out for you. Either way, it's reassuring to know that you can raise a healthy baby on **formula**.

Bottle-feeding your baby

Why bottle-feed

There is a lot of pressure put on new moms to breast-feed, but some women are uncomfortable with breast-feeding, or are unable to breast-feed. It's important that your baby gets the right amount of food to grow, so try not to worry about where her nourishment comes from; you will give her a good start in life with formula. Feeding your baby from either the breast or a bottle is a wonderful bonding experience. Some moms express breast milk from the beginning and their baby drinks it from a bottle, while others combine breast and bottle-feeding. There are some advantages to bottle-feeding. First, someone other than you can prepare and give a feeding, giving you time to rest. Second, bottle-fed babies tend to have fewer feedings. Third, they generally sleep better at night (after the first few weeks) since they're less likely to wake up for a feeding—cow's milk forms a more solid curd that takes longer to digest than breast milk. If you bottle-feed from the beginning, it will take around seven to 10 days for the milk your breasts produced after the birth to dry up, during which time your breasts may feel heavy and full.

First feeds

Your newborn needs to be fed little and often, so offer her the bottle when you notice her hunger cues (see p.269). Young babies are especially vulnerable to germs while their immunity builds up, so be meticulous about hygiene rules when preparing feedings and sanitizing bottles and nipples. Bottle-fed babies take in more air during feedings (their mouths form less of a seal around the bottle's nipple compared to your nipple) so burp your baby regularly.

Switching to bottle-feeding

If you want to go from breast to formula feedings, or to give bottles of expressed breast milk, you will need to get equipped with bottles, nipples, and a cleaning system (see p.191). Some bottles boast a similar feel to your own nipple to help a baby make the switch from breast to bottle. If you want to continue breast-feeding while trying a bottle, called combination feeding, start with one bottle a day, so that your baby gets used to the different taste and the feel of it. It can help if your partner does the first few bottle feedings until your baby gets used to the bottle.